

FAMILY MATTERS

TEXT: Genesis 2:15-24 (NKJV) *“Then the Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to tend and keep it. ¹⁶ And the Lord God commanded the man, saying, “Of every tree of the garden you may freely eat; ¹⁷ but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die.” ¹⁸ And the Lord God said, “It is not good that man should be alone; I will make him a helper comparable to him.” ¹⁹ Out of the ground the Lord God formed every beast of the field and every bird of the air, and brought them to Adam to see what he would call them. And whatever Adam called each living creature, that was its name. ²⁰ So Adam gave names to all cattle, to the birds of the air, and to every beast of the field. But for Adam there was not found a helper comparable to him.*

²¹ And the Lord God caused a deep sleep to fall on Adam, and he slept; and He took one of his ribs, and closed up the flesh in its place. ²²

Then the rib which the Lord God had taken from man He made into a woman, and He brought her to the man. ²³ And Adam said:

“This is now bone of my bones And flesh of my flesh; She shall be called Woman, Because she was taken out of Man.” ²⁴ Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and they shall become one flesh.”

INTRO:

There are several things in this scripture I would like to point out:

- God said, *“It is not good that man should be alone...”* Never has been – Never will be!
- God made him a helper comparable to him... She is not your old lady, she is your

companion – Your partner – Your sweetheart!

- God called Eve, woman... Wo-Man! He can call her that but you can't!
- You were made out of dirt – She was made from a rib... Don't forget it! We've come a long way's baby – From Adam's rib to women's lib!
- Adam said, “*She is flesh of my flesh and bone of my bones.*”... Adam was saying that he was inextricably connected to His life's mate – More people need to view this relationship in this way!

As we discover in the relationship with Adam and Eve everything was not perfect in the First Family! Sin entered the picture and with sin came brokenness and dysfunction! When they

sinned, Eve blamed the serpent, and Adam blamed Eve. It wasn't long until their children were blaming each other too. The situation quickly spiraled out of control, and Cain killed Able. If you don't believe you have dysfunction in your family call for a family reunion. (I rest my case)

So, if all relationships have brokenness and dysfunction, especially marriages, what is the answer?

SPIRITUALITY

Spirituality sounds like an easy way to fix brokenness and dysfunction – Right?

Building a healthy relationship is just what it sounds like – Work! (Nasty little four letter word)

There is no such thing as a perfect marriage or a marriage made in heaven. All marriages are created, consummated, developed, and perfected right here on earth!

The earth, not Heaven is where the success or failure of your marriage will rise or fall. The most important question I could ask, “*How committed are you to your marriage?*”

No marriage can be successful or pleasant unless both partners are committed to the relationship and are willing to do whatever is necessary to make it successful.

Marriage is all about two people finding their place, doing their part and running in their lane. In speaking to the Ephesian church, Paul quotes the words of the Lord from Genesis two.

Ephesians 5:31 (NKJV) “***For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh.***” Leaving and cleaving – Two becoming one - At its best this is a tedious, painful process.

How do two different and unique individuals become one? By sharing a common spiritual bond and by sharing the truth about themselves with one another. No Secrets! FAMILY MATTERS, BUT SPIRITUALITY MATTERS TOO!

My wedding ring say's in Hebrew – *“I am my beloved's and my beloved is mine”* – Here is what spirituality looks like - When you get married you are no longer your own – You belong to Jesus and to your spouse – When you get married you must assume third place – Jesus, your spouse, and then & only then, your needs.

Marriage is a developmental process, not an event that became complete when you fell in love. Living things grow and change. That is precisely why we must WORK at building a healthy, spiritual relationship.

Too often people fall in love, get married, and their relationship then proceeds to wither and die because it is assumed that everything after

the altar is automatic. FAMILY MATTERS
AND SPIRITUALITY MATTERS!

Marriage is a living developmental process that needs nurturing and care in order for it to grow and thrive. Give your marriage proper attention and it will grow, neglect it and it will die. The choice is yours, invest some hard work and build a healthy relationship, or get a second job to pay the attorneys, and child support!

**(I WILL NEED A WHITE BOARD TO
WRITE THIS ON – HAVE CAMERA
READY TO PROJECT IT ONTO THE
SCREEN AS I WRITE IT)**

1 Person + 1 Person = Conflict

1 Person in love + 1 Person in love = Conflict

As a Christian we recognize that we have experienced brokenness in relationship to God. The Gospel recounts God's actions to reconcile that broken relationship. *“While we were yet in our sins Christ died for us...” “As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions...” “For God so loved the world that He gave...”*

Forgiveness is the action that God took which resulted in our redemption, restoration and reconciliation. The act of forgiveness allows us to live beyond the power of the past.

Forgiveness is the first step to spirituality. When we refuse to forgive our spiritual life is permanently stunted right there. When we fail to forgive our spouse's, our marriage is stunted right there! (Man who said to the marriage counselor *“My wife gets all historical...”*)

We are not perfect, none of us! (Preacher who asked if anyone in the audience had ever known a perfect person) Imperfection brings about brokenness in all of our relationships including our marriages. Brokenness (Sometimes referred to as baggage) produces the need for forgiveness. Forgiveness sets the guilty party as well as the innocent party free.

Forgiveness allows us to live for the future by allowing God to take the pain out of a past experience for us! (Joseph – Manasseh)

**FAMILY MATTERS AND SPIRITUALITY
MATTERS!**

Since neither of the parties in a marriage is perfect, forgiveness and reconciliation are vitally important aspects of an enduring relationship. A successful marriage is one where

each party has developed a willingness to ask for and offer forgiveness.

Spirituality involves one's relationship to God and the expression of that relationship in everyday life. Spirituality includes:

- Prayer...
- Family devotions...
- Church attendance...
- Tithing...
- Core values...
- Priorities...
- Common ground...

CONCLUSION:

If we have not already done so, we should start making history as a couple spiritually by implementing these things.

(Have all couples to come forward and repeat a prayer of forgiveness and a commitment to spirituality in their marriage – *“Dear Lord Jesus, I thank you for the companion you have blessed me with. Today I want to make a commitment to you and to my spouse. I commit to being honest – I commit to being fair – I commit to preferring my spouse above myself – I commit to doing all the things I need to do, in order to have a healthy and spiritual marriage relationship. I offer total forgiveness to my spouse today. From this day forward, I will not bring up the past. Beginning now, I will only look to the future. As freely as you forgave me, I forgive my spouse. I commit to pray together – I*

*commit to do family devotions together – I
commit to faithfully attend church together – I
commit to join my spouse in establishing and
living by core values for our family together – I
commit to join my spouse in establishing
priorities for our family together – I commit to
always seek common ground with my spouse – I
ask for your blessing upon our marriage as
never before, in Jesus name, Amen.)*

FAMILY MATTERS - MONEY MATTERS

Luke 14:28-30 (ESV) “*For which of you, desiring to build a tower, does not first sit down and count the cost, whether he has enough to complete it? Otherwise, when he has laid a foundation and is not able to finish, all who see it begin to mock him, saying, ‘This man began to build and was not able to finish.’”*

FAMILY MATTERS BUT MONEY

MATTERS TOO – In fact it matters so much that the Bible has more to say on this subject than almost any other subject – Yet, the church is almost silent on the subject! The reason the Bible is so vocal on this subject is that God knew that literally every earthly action and transaction has to do with finances! (Elaborate on this – Prosperity vs. Poverty)

Some studies suggest that the number one cause of stress in marriages is money. This stress is usually related to four basic issues:

- There isn't enough money... Sometimes there isn't enough money to meet the basic needs of the household. In which case the lifestyle must change, someone must take on an extra or part time job, or someone has to

find a better paying job. MONEY MATTERS!

- Unrealistic expectations... More times than not, the problem among young married couples is unrealistic expectations. (Don't forget, it took your parents 20 + years to accumulate what they have!) Ernie Zelinski said, *"Everyone seems to want to be somewhere they aren't. Choose to be where you are right now and you will be happier than 90% of humankind."* We are bombarded daily with noise that tells us what we need. From television ads, to social media, to what we see our neighbors with, we are constantly being fed a diet of "more". (Call from a lady at the Infinity dealer this week – 0% financing!!!) Nearly two-thirds of all marriages start off in debt. 86 percent of couples married five years or less started off in the red. They are leveraging their

futures away to enjoy something today.

They think that they will pay everything off together, as a couple. But most of the time, their financial situation gets worse before it gets better. Voicemail message: *"Hi. This is Steve. If you are the phone company, I already sent the money. If you are my parents, please send money. If you are my bank loan officer, you didn't lend me enough money. If you are my friends, you owe me money. If you are female, don't worry, I have plenty of money."* (My dad was not happy when I bought my first new car after getting married – I was offended that he was not happy for me) MONEY MATTERS!

- Lack of proper management skills... In this case there is enough money to meet the needs, but the couple does not possess the management skills required to make financial ends meet. When money is not

handled wisely disastrous consequences are to be expected. (If you will carefully attend the little money, the big money will take care of itself) A man calls a financial planner seeking some advice and direction. *"Hello. My name is Bob. I'd like to invest some money."* *"Hello Bob, this is Mike. I would be happy to meet you. You say you would like to invest some money. First, to help me better understand your situation, can you tell me where or how you currently have your money invested?"* *"Sure Mike. I am currently invested in Credit Cards, Car Loans, Student Loans, and the Lottery."*
MONEY MATTERS!

- Different value systems... Many marriage counselors will tell you the man should handle the finances and others would tell you the woman should handle the money. (Conservative vs. liberal) The conservative

money manager should manage the family finances. No matter who handles the finances each couple should sit down after the first of each month and review everything that came in and everything that went out for the previous month.

Accountability is a great thing. If one knows this meeting is going to happen it will cause each person to think twice before spending. This seems restrictive but marriage is a partnership and no one should be in the dark about the finances in a partnership. If neither person is good with money an independent person should be invited to assist in managing the marital finances. One-third of people who say that they argue about money in their marriage say that they hide purchases from their spouse because they know their spouse would not approve. (Is that new? No, I have had this a long time!)

There's a saying that says, "*Theirs was a perfect marriage, except one fatal flaw--one was quick on the deposit, but the other was quicker on the draw!*" MONEY MATTERS!

If money is to be managed correctly each family should be able to do what is right by their family, by their church and ***“leave an inheritance to their children’s children.”***

The average church member:

- Gives 1.8% of their income to the church...
- Gives 8% of their income to the mortgage company...
- Gives 11% of their income to the car finance company...
- Gives 18% of their income or more, to credit card companies...

FAMILY MATTERS BUT MONEY MATTERS TOO!

Studies consistently show that people's personal savings rates have drastically fallen:

- In 1984, people saved an average of 10.8% of their income...
- In 1993 people saved 5% of their income...
- Today people save 1% of their income...

Current studies show that the average household in America is spending \$1.10 to every dollar they make.

CONCLUSION:

Proverbs 13:11 “... *he who gathers money little by little makes it grow.*”

We do not have to live our lives in a financial struggle. MONEY MATTERS!

Here is a good rule of thumb for properly budgeting for success:

- 10% to God...
- 10% savings...
- 33% to taxes...
- 47% to live on...

Our families do not have to fall apart. Our homes do not have to live under a constant state of stress, anger, frustration, and worry.

It is God's will for us to be:

- The head and not the tail...
- Above and not beneath...

- The lender, not the borrower...

Proverbs 6:6-8 ***“Go to the ant, you sluggard!
Consider her ways and be wise, ⁷ Which,
having no captain, Overseer or ruler,
⁸ Provides her supplies in the summer,
And gathers her food in the harvest.”***

It's time that we live by Kingdom finances, not American finances. If we truly believe that we are to be in this world but not of it, our finances should look different than those “of” this world. We shouldn't have the same debt. We shouldn't have the same financial stress. We should be the lenders, not the borrowers. Our children should understand money. We have no excuses because we have the playbook. Tithe. Save. Spend less than you make. FAMILY MATTERS BUT MONEY MATTERS TOO!

Many people want God to give them a financial breakthrough or for Him to help them win the lottery or the publishers clearinghouse sweepstakes. What God wants to give them is:

- A job...
- A second job...
- Financial management skills...

FAMILY MATTERS BUT MONEY MATTERS TOO!

Thomas Edison said, *"Genius is one percent inspiration, and 99 percent perspiration."* He also said, *"Opportunity is missed by most people because it is dressed in overalls and looks like work."* MONEY MATTERS!

FAMILY MATTERS – SEXUALITY MATTERS

1 Corinthians 7:2-5 *“But since there is so much immorality, each man should have his own wife, and each woman her own husband. 3 The husband should fulfill his marital duty to his wife, and likewise the wife to her husband. 4 The wife's body does not belong to her alone but also to her husband. In the same way, the husband's body does not belong to him alone but also to his wife. 5 Do not deprive each other except by mutual consent and for a time, so that you may devote yourselves to prayer. Then come together again so that Satan will not tempt you because of your lack of self-control.”*

We live in a society that is obsessed with sexual activity. This obsession has led us to believe

that sexual intercourse or associated physical sexual activity is synonymous with intimacy.

Couples feel great pressure to live up to the sexual call our society sends out. As a result, many feel frustrated or unsuccessful in marriage if sex is not all it's cracked up to be on TV or in other media forms. If we hold sexual activity at the center of our plan for intimacy in marriage we will no doubt be very disappointed at some point in the marriage. Sex between marriage partners should occupy a high priority but it cannot be the thing that everything else is judged by.

The sexual relationship between a husband and wife should be a wonderful expression of intimacy. In a well-adjusted marriage each partner is at least as concerned about the other

persons needs and growth as they are about their own pleasure and satisfaction. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS!

If our marriages are Biblically based, we will have a very healthy physical relationship with our spouse. (Lady at Fouke who brought a “*Better than sex*” cake to a pot- luck dinner)

There is nothing better than good sex and there is nothing worse than bad sex. Sex is more than a physical act it is an emotional and spiritual interaction between two people God intentionally put together.

As married people we have a tremendous biblical responsibility toward our spouses in the arena of sexuality. God's first commandment to man was a sexual commandment, "*Be fruitful,*

and multiply, and replenish the earth."

(Genesis 1:28) The Bible says Adam "***knew***" his wife. Adam made love to Eve and she became pregnant. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS!

God is the creator of sex but this culture has hijacked it, distorted it and perverted it. God brought Eve to Adam. The perversion was not so in the beginning. Genesis 2:25 "***They were both naked, the man and his wife, and were not ashamed."***

A rule that must be honored in all marriages is that only what is enjoyable to both partners should be permitted. At the same time we must keep the needs of our spouse in mind and there are times we must bench our selfish, prudish

ideas. Hebrews 13:4 *"Marriage is honorable in all, and the bed undefiled."*

Your body is not your own, you gave it to your partner at the altar when you said your marriage vows. 1 Corinthians 7:2-5 *"But since there is so much immorality, each man should have his own wife, and each woman her own husband. 3 The husband should fulfill his marital duty to his wife, and likewise the wife to her husband. 4 The wife's body does not belong to her alone but also to her husband. In the same way, the husband's body does not belong to him alone but also to his wife. 5 Do not deprive each other except by mutual consent and for a time, so that you may devote yourselves to prayer. Then come together again so that Satan will not tempt you because of your lack*

of self-control.” Four central principles taught in 1 Corinthians 7:2-5 concerning sex:

- Both the husband and the wife have sexual needs and drives that should be fulfilled inside their marriage... If this does not happen the person who is withholding themselves from their partner is sinning against God, the marriage covenant and their mate.
- When one marries they forfeit control of their body to their partner... Both parties of a marriage relationship should seek opportunities to satisfy their mate. A healthy, exciting sexual relationship takes work and the individual that fails to work in this area is inviting disaster to wreck the marriage. To not do so is a sin against God, the marriage covenant and their mate.

- Both partners are forbidden to refuse to meet the sexual needs of their mate... This command is more than being available, this is a command to do everything physically, emotionally and sexually possible to keep the attention and affection of our spouse focused on us. (Alienation of affection) If this does not occur one should not be too shocked when one discovers their spouse has a wandering eye or has been unfaithful. If sex is not enjoyable (Lack of a sex drive – Uncomfortable - Painful) to one of the marriage partners it is up to that person to seek every remedy possible. (Doctor – Marriage counselor etc...) Otherwise they leave themselves, their partner and the marriage itself at risk of temptation. To not do so is a sin against God, the marriage covenant and their mate.

- The act of sex within a marriage is approved by God and must be treated as such by all who commit to the marriage covenant... The Bible talks about “*Due benevolence*” inferring that people who enter into Holy marriage automatically assume a debt of lovemaking to their spouse. (Gallon jar full of beans) We should guard against being a deadbeat husband or wife in this area. To not do so is to sin against God, the marriage covenant and our mate.

FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS!

Lets look at what lovemaking means to a man:

1) It satisfies his sex drive... (Now lets look at what lovemaking means to a woman! Ha!) It is generally agreed that the male in most species of living creatures has the stronger sex drive. So

it's not a problem that your husband has a corner on! Women have sex drive, but theirs is normally sporadic, whereas, a man's sex drive is almost continual. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS TOO!

2) It fulfills his manhood... A man usually possesses a stronger ego than a woman and it is a scientifically proven fact that his sex drive is linked to his ego. This is not abnormal. It is completely normal. A husband has a need to know that his wife thoroughly enjoys his lovemaking. The old Victorian nonsense that a "*nice lady*" doesn't act as if she enjoys sex conflicts with this.

A secure man becomes a better father, uses better judgment, and improves his capacity to love the entire family when his wife is meeting

his sexual needs. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS TOO!

3) It enhances his ability to show his love for his wife... Because God has endowed a man with an intense sex drive and a conscience, the satisfactory release of that drive without provoking his conscience will enhance his love for the person who makes that possible.

But only one person on earth should do that - his wife. If his wife is not fully engaged in meeting this need she is sinning against God, the marriage covenant and her husband. If the husband is not being the kind of man that causes his wife to want to meet his needs he is sinning against God, the marriage covenant and his wife. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS TOO!

4) It reduces friction in the home... I have counseled with women who refuse to make love to their husbands for long periods of time because they are mad that he treats them better after sex. Let me ask you a question. If when you performed certain responsibilities in your place of employment you were treated better by the boss, and actually received promotions and raises because you went above and beyond the call of duty, would you not be happy to do a little extra? What about your husband?

FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY
MATTERS TOO!

5) For a man, sex provides life's most exciting experience... (Susan asked me one day, “*Why do you suppose God made sex?*” My response – “*Because he knew I would not have wanted to*

live if he hadn't!") Sex is at the top of the list of things a man would rather do. (Guy that came to my house to complain that all his wife wanted to do was make love)

Men let me share the words of Jesus with you about your sex drive and thought life. Matthew 5:28, ***"I say unto you that whosoever, looketh on a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart."***

Vain imaginations can be very destructive to your marital relationship. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS TOO!

Let's look at what lovemaking means to a woman:

1) It fulfills her womanhood... If a woman considers herself unsuccessful in bed, she will have a difficult time accepting her total womanhood.

A wife is more than a mother and a homemaker. She is also a sexual partner to her mate.

FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY
MATTERS TOO!

2) It reassures her of her husband's love... There are five kinds of love required by a woman.

- Companionship love. Few women enjoy solitude for long periods of time. Have you noticed how few hermits and recluses are women?

- Compassionate love. A woman has a natural bedside manner, but only a few men display that kind of compassion.
- Romantic love. Women are romantics! She is looking for her knight in shining armor. For that reason she needs romance, flowers, music, soft lights, dinner out, and a host of other things. Romance is more than just making sure the door to the bedroom is locked! Some men think foreplay is telling their wife to brace herself! Ladies, I want you to make a top-ten-list of things you consider to be romantic acts then give it to your husband! He may need a little jump-starting! Just be careful not to kick-start him! (Story about some beagles trying to jump-start a rabbit on a cold day)

Gentlemen, make sure the romantic adventure you have planned is for her best interest and not your own.

- Affectionate love. Most women crave kisses of appreciation, which have nothing to do with sex. To women a tender touch, a warm embrace, and the closeness of the one they love is almost as enjoyable as the more intimate sexual contact. Song of Solomon 1:2 ***"Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth: for thy love is better than wine, because of the savour of thy good ointments thy name is as ointment poured forth..."***
- Passionate love. Impassioned love comes naturally to a man because of his stronger sex drive. Most women have to cultivate the appetite for passionate lovemaking, but they do have the capacity to learn. It is easier for

a woman to express passionate love after the other four needs for love have been satisfied.
FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY
MATTERS TOO!

3) It satisfies her sex drive... Although a woman may not possess as strong or consistent a sex drive as a man, she does have a sex drive. If she doesn't there is either a physical, emotional or relational problem. And, if this is the case, professional help should be sought sooner rather than later.

A woman does not seem so readily tempted to fantasize, as does her husband. However, she does have the capacity to remember romantically those exciting experiences of her past. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY
MATTERS TOO!

4) It relaxes her nervous system... Frigid women are nervous women. Note: not every nervous woman is frigid. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS TOO!

5) The ultimate experience... Sexual involvement and activity, like every other part of the relationship, will change and grow with time - whether one pays attention or not - this could be productive or counterproductive. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS TOO!

CONCLUSION:

One should ask their partner questions to find out if the sexual experience is pleasurable or not? The best intimate sexual expression is a

well-informed sexual expression. Hebrews 13:4
***“Marriage is honorable, and the bed
undefiled....”***

Intimate sex recognizes a wealth of opportunities for intimate physical expression outside of the context of intercourse. Recreation (Doing a hobby together), a caring back-rub, a foot-rub, a quiet cup of coffee together, are all opportunities for intimate expression.

Keep, others out of your bedroom! Example - Alcohol, Drugs, Pornography, Magazines, Books, Violence, Fantasies, etc. The more purified our character, the more responsive our spouse. FAMILY MATTERS AND SEXUALITY MATTERS TOO!

